WHAT IS DIGITAL ADDICTION?

Call it screen, internet, social media or gaming addiction, the root cause for the evil is the excessive use of digital devices. A Vivo-CMR (CyberMediaResearch) study titled 'Smartphones and their Impact on Human Relationships, 2021', which surveyed 2,000 respondents in the 18-45 age group in New Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad and Kolkata, found that 84 per cent of the cohort checked their phones within the first 15 minutes of waking up, and 46 per cent picked up the phone at least five times in an hour. And despite a majority claiming that phone overuse was affecting their mental and physical health as well as relationships, 74 per cent said they could not put their devices away because it made them moody and depressed. "My problem," says 21-year-old Pune University student Pratishtha Khattar, "is that life without a mobile phone is impossible today. I know there is something called overuse but I do not know the line, and even if I cross it, I do not know what harm it is doing to me." However, as Dr Ajeenkya D.Y. Patil, chairman of the Ajeenkya DY Patil Group, points out, "Screen time addiction is real and is associated with very serious repercussions."

In fact, in an alarming revelation, a report by the Indian Academy of Pediatrics titled 'Indian Academy of Pediatrics Guidelines on Screen Time and Digital Wellness in Infants, Children and Adolescents' in 2021 noted that even two-month-old babies are being exposed to the mobile phone. On an average, newborns in India get their first exposure to smart phones (96 per cent) or TV screens (89 per cent) within 10 months. This when the American Academy of Pediatrics recommends zero digital media exposure for children under 18 months, and only an hour a day for children aged two to five.

Adolescents, however, are the most likely to fall prey to the digital lure as confirmed by a meta analysis of 50 studies in 19 Indian states published in medical journal *The BMJ* in 2021. It found the risk of internet addiction in college-going students to be between 20 and 40 per cent.

So overpowering is digital life today that people stay up night after night glued to their devices. "We cannot fall asleep till we have read the news on our mobile phones," admits Onkar Kapur, a 29-year-old engineer in Bengaluru. "Why, sometimes I reach out for my phone even in the middle of the night. I know it is not healthy, but often I do it without realising it." In fact, last month, mattress company Wakefit released a compilation of over 200,000 responses over six years in which 87 per cent confessed to using their phones compulsively before they went to sleep.

Feeding the monster of digital addiction is social media. With over 400 million users, India is the largest user base of social networking giant Facebook. We also have the largest number of Whatsapp users in the world at close to 500 million. The Global Web Index's Social Media Trends 2019 report cites the results of a survey conducted in 45 countries among 278,000 respondents, including 15,000 Indians, which finds that digital consumers in this country spend around 2.4 hours every day on social networks and messaging—a little more than the global daily average of 2 hours and 24 minutes.

Before long, what was once seen as a technological

SIGNS OF TROUBLE

YOU KNOW YOU ARE ADDICTED IF YOU...

- Check your phone or laptop in the middle of the night
- Are willing to sacrifice sleep, work, food or relationships for more screen time
- Feel stressed, angry or depressed when you are denied access to a screen
- Cannot attend offline experiences without posting about them online
- Spend more than eight hours a day on a screen
- Have your phone impacting your job or academic performance
- Have well-wishers repeatedly voicing concerns about your pattern of phone use
- Relapse within a few hours when you try to go on a detox